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EDU 101: Foundations of Education - Purpose, History and Practice

What education is for, and how schools actually work

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Education
Educational Foundations | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Education students often memorise definitions without understanding the debates underneath them. This pack covers the meaning and aims of education, major philosophies, the Nigerian education system and the basics of curriculum and assessment.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish education, schooling and indoctrination.
- Compare major educational philosophies and their classroom implications.
- Describe the structure and levels of the Nigerian education system.
- Explain curriculum, pedagogy and assessment as connected decisions.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What education is

Education is a deliberate process of developing knowledge, skills, attitudes and values. Schooling is one institution through which it happens.

- Formal education is structured and certified; informal education is embedded in daily life; non-formal education is organised but flexible.
- Indoctrination closes inquiry; education opens it. The distinction lies in method and intent.
- Aims include intellectual development, social efficiency, citizenship, moral development and self-actualisation.
- Education is both a right and an instrument of national development.

- Nigerian policy defines basic education broadly, including junior secondary.
- Teachers exercise authority, which makes ethical self-awareness essential.

Educational philosophies

Philosophy answers what knowledge is and what teaching should therefore look like.

- Idealism: emphasises ideas and moral formation; teacher as model.
- Realism: emphasises observation and the natural order.
- Pragmatism and progressivism: learning through experience and problem solving; teacher as facilitator.
- Essentialism: core knowledge and discipline transmitted systematically.
- Constructivism: learners build understanding from prior knowledge and activity.
- Perennialism: enduring ideas and canonical texts.

> **Theory to classroom**
> Examiners love the question 'what does this mean for teaching practice?' Always move from the philosophy to a concrete classroom behaviour.

System, curriculum and assessment

Curriculum is what is intended to be learned; instruction is how it is taught; assessment is how we know whether it was learned.

- Nigerian structure: early childhood, nine years of basic education, three years of senior secondary, then tertiary.
- A curriculum includes objectives, content, methods and evaluation.
- Bloom's taxonomy orders cognitive objectives from remembering to creating.
- Assessment types: diagnostic, formative and summative.
- Valid assessment measures what it claims; reliable assessment is consistent.
- Continuous assessment reduces the weight of a single examination and provides feedback.

What education is for: four competing answers

Every education system rests on an answer to the question "what is education for?", and the answers conflict. The transmission answer says education passes on the knowledge and values a society needs. The developmental answer says it cultivates the whole person. The economic answer says it produces skills for employment and growth. The critical answer says it should equip people to question the society they inherit.

These are not compatible in practice. A curriculum designed for measurable skills crowds out time for open inquiry; a curriculum designed for critical consciousness may not produce the specific competencies employers demand. Recognising the conflict is the first analytic move in this course, because most policy debates are really arguments between these purposes.

Nigerian education policy carries all four at once. The National Policy on Education speaks of self-reliance, citizenship, scientific literacy and employability, and the tension between them is visible whenever funding, assessment or curriculum is discussed.

The institutions and their history

Formal education in Nigeria has three roots: indigenous education (apprenticeship, oral instruction, age-grade training, moral formation), Islamic education (Qur'anic schools and later scholarship), and Western missionary schooling from the mid-nineteenth century. Each had its own curriculum, its own authority and its own purposes, and their interaction shaped the modern system.

The 6-3-3-4 structure introduced in the 1980s, later revised toward 9-3-4, defines primary, junior secondary, senior secondary and tertiary stages. Understanding the structure matters because each transition is an examination gate, and the gates determine who continues.

Access has expanded dramatically since independence, but quality and equity have not kept pace. Out-of-school children, teacher supply, infrastructure, and the rural-urban gap are structural problems, not individual failures.

> **Policy is a set of trade-offs**
> When you evaluate a policy, name what it gains and what it costs. A policy with no costs is a slogan.

Teachers, learners and the classroom

Educational psychology supplies the working knowledge a teacher needs: how attention and memory operate, why spaced practice beats cramming, how motivation differs between intrinsic and extrinsic forms, and why feedback that names the next step is more effective than a grade alone.

Classroom management is not discipline. It is the design of routines, expectations and physical arrangements that make learning possible. A well-managed classroom has predictable procedures, visible purposes and a teacher who notices individuals.

Assessment has two functions that are often confused: assessment of learning (summative, for reporting) and assessment for learning (formative, to guide the next step). A system that uses only the first turns education into a ranking exercise and loses most of its diagnostic power.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Evaluating a policy claim

A state announces free primary education. Assess the claim.

1. Define "free": no fees, or no fees plus no levies, uniforms and materials?
2. Identify the funding source and whether it is recurrent or one-off.
3. Predict the enrolment effect and the capacity response: classrooms, teachers, materials.
4. Identify the quality risk: overcrowding and teacher workload.
5. Name the equity effect: which children are still excluded - girls, disabled children, rural households?
6. Conclude with what evidence would show the policy succeeded.

> **What to carry forward**
> Define the term, follow the money, predict the response, name the excluded.

2. Turning a theory into a classroom decision

Apply spaced practice to a two-week revision period.

1. Identify the material to be retained.
2. Divide it into four units rather than one block.
3. Schedule short revisits at increasing intervals rather than one long cram.
4. Include retrieval practice: closed-book recall, not rereading.
5. Build in feedback that corrects errors immediately.
6. Measure retention at the end by testing the earliest unit.

> **What to carry forward**
> Theory earns its place when it changes what you do on Monday.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Discuss the competing purposes of education and their implications for curriculum.

20 marks

1. Name the four purposes: transmission, development, economic, critical.
2. Explain what each implies for content and assessment.
3. Show two concrete tensions.
4. Relate to Nigerian policy language.
5. Conclude that curriculum is a negotiated compromise, not a neutral selection.

Q2. Distinguish assessment of learning from assessment for learning.

10 marks

1. Define summative and formative functions.
2. Give one example of each in a classroom.
3. Explain the consequence of using only summative assessment.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Curriculum. The planned content, sequence and assessment of a course of study.

Pedagogy. The method and theory of teaching.

Indigenous education. Learning through apprenticeship, oral instruction and community participation.

Formative assessment. Assessment used to guide the next step in learning.

Summative assessment. Assessment used to report achievement at the end of a period.

Spaced practice. Distributing study over time rather than massing it.

Retrieval practice. Recalling information from memory to strengthen retention.

Intrinsic motivation. Engagement driven by interest or satisfaction in the activity itself.

Equity. Fairness in access and outcomes, accounting for different starting points.

6-3-3-4. The Nigerian education structure of six primary, three junior secondary, three senior secondary and four tertiary years.

Hidden curriculum. Lessons transmitted through school routines and expectations rather than formal content.

Self-reliance. A stated aim of Nigerian education emphasising practical and entrepreneurial capability.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Purposes

Aims.

- Write the four purposes in your own words.
- Find each in the national policy.
- Identify one conflict.

Week 2 - History

Institutions.

- Timeline the three roots of Nigerian education.
- Explain one missionary legacy.
- Map the 6-3-3-4 stages.

Week 3 - Learning

Psychology applied.

- Design a spaced revision plan.
- Write three formative questions.
- Plan feedback that names the next step.

Week 4 - Policy

Evaluation.

- Assess one real policy claim.
- Name the excluded group.
- Write a 20-mark answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- The current Nigerian National Policy on Education.
- An introduction to the sociology and philosophy of education.
- A text on educational psychology covering memory, motivation and assessment.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish education from indoctrination.

Answer: Education develops the ability to question and reason; indoctrination instils beliefs while suppressing critical examination.

2. What is the difference between formal and non-formal education?

Answer: Formal education follows a structured curriculum in institutions and leads to certification. Non-formal education is organised learning outside the formal system, such as adult literacy classes.

3. State one classroom implication of constructivism.

Answer: Teaching should begin from learners' prior knowledge and use activities or problems that require them to build new understanding.

4. Differentiate formative from summative assessment.

Answer: Formative assessment occurs during learning to guide improvement; summative assessment occurs at the end to judge achievement.

5. List two aims of education.

Answer: Intellectual development and preparation for responsible citizenship.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write your own definition of education and defend it in three sentences.
- [ ] Compare three educational philosophies in a table.
- [ ] Draw the structure of the Nigerian education system.
- [ ] List the components of a curriculum.
- [ ] Classify five assessment tasks as diagnostic, formative or summative.
- [ ] Explain validity and reliability with an example each.
- [ ] Observe a lesson and identify the dominant teaching approach.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: